ANGELS OF RURAL FINANCE

By linking socially conscious investors with rural entrepreneurs long excluded from formal banking, Rang De is making credit not just inclusive, but flexible and fair too

By **SONAL KHETARPAL**

On a quiet street in Kohima, 40-year-old **Neilhoupeu Koza** looked at the shelves of her small apparel shop and dreamed of expansion. For that, she needed Rs 1.5 lakh. Miles away, in Bihar's Supaul district, Gita Devi, who runs a modest fish farm, was worried about something far more immediate: buying feed worth Rs 20,000. For both women, these were not just loans, they were lifelines.

Their struggles are echoed by millions across India. Despite a decade of financial inclusion drives, 86 per cent of eligible Indians still remain outside the reach of formal credit. The gap



Photograph by **HEMANT MISHRA**